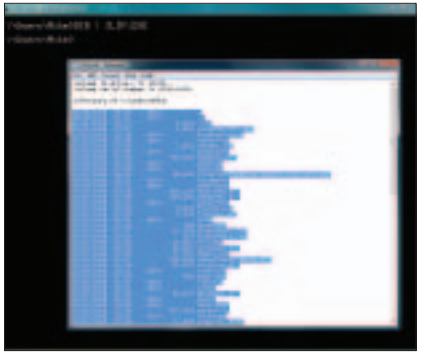
Learn the secrets of Command Prompt

Hidden beneath Vista's new interface is a better method of carrying out common tasks

In the early days of personal computers there was no graphical Explorer-type interface, no drag and drop, point and click, or any of the other conveniences we now take for granted. Users instead had to learn cryptic text commands to perform even the simplest of PC tasks. It was all very complicated, which is probably why most people now ignore the last remnant of those days: the Windows Command Prompt.

In fact, the Command Prompt never went away and is still there, even in Windows Vista. Not only that, but Vista's prompt is actually an efficient way to enter all kinds of useful commands, many of which perform handy PC management tasks that you simply can't carry out in any other way. It's also easy to use and, with just a little practice, anyone can start entering commands and make their PC run more smoothly.

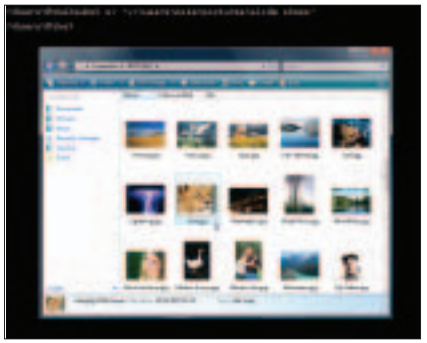
Tip 1

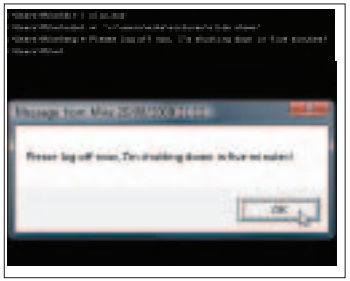


It may look old-fashioned, but the Command Prompt has functionality you won't find elsewhere. Windows Explorer can't print a list of all the files in a folder, for example, but with the Command Prompt it's easy. Hold down shift, right-click on a folder and select Open Command Window Here. A command prompt window will appear, with a prompt telling you the current folder (`c:\Users\YourName\Desktop\FolderName >`, for example). Type `DIR | CLIP.EXE` and press Enter on your keyboard. The `DIR` command means 'list everything in this directory' (or folder); the `|` symbol is called a pipe, and sends the listing to another program; and `CLIP.EXE` places the list in the clipboard. Switch back to your Desktop, launch Notepad (`Start > All Programs > Accessories > Notepad`) and click `Edit > Paste` to see your files, then save or print them.

Tip 2

Finding folders can sometimes be tricky, especially when they're deeply embedded, such as `c:\programfiles\appname\data\examples\sample1\look\here`. So it's just as well that the Command Prompt has a solution. Click Start, type `cmd.exe` in the Search box and press Enter on your keyboard to launch the command prompt. Type `SUBST W: "C:\Folder"` and press Enter, where `W:` is replaced by any unused drive letter on your system, and `"C:\Folder"` is replaced by the path you'd like to access more easily. Now open Explorer and you'll see a new `W:` drive. Click that and it will take you directly to `C:\Folder` (or whichever folder you specified). Browse this or drag and drop files there as you like. When you are done, type `SUBST W: /D` and press Enter to remove the `W:` drive, but don't worry — it is only getting rid of the drive alias; your data remains untouched.





Tip 3

The Command Prompt can help you manage a home network. If you want to turn off your PC but several network users are logged in, then you can send them all a warning with the msg command. Open a Command Prompt, type something like